

Few, a few, little, and a little

Learner workbook

Express a small amount with the intended emphasis.

Understand the distinction

Use few and a few for small numbers of countable plural nouns. Use little and a little for small amounts of an uncountable noun. Few/little often stress a shortage; a few/a little stress that some are available.

Context decides whether an amount is enough. A few does not promise a sufficient number. Little can also be an adjective meaning small, as in little houses or little people; that is a different use from the quantity word.

Compare the patterns

SMALL NUMBER

I have a few questions.

There are some questions.

SHORTAGE

We have little time.

The speaker emphasizes the small amount.

SOME AVAILABLE

We have a little time.

The speaker emphasizes that some time remains.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose for an amount: a little advice / a few advice

2. Which usually sounds more positive: few friends / a few friends?

3. Must little houses mean a small number of houses?

Use it in your own life

Describe a small amount you have and a shortage you face.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. a little advice

Advice is normally uncountable.

2. a few friends

It emphasizes having some friends.

3. No. It normally means small houses.

Little can describe physical size.

One possible response

I have a little time this evening, but few free hours this week.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-27.html